FDE INTERVIEW PREP #01

FDE INTERVIEW PREP · ISSUE 01 OF 08

LLM apps: RAG, evals, guardrails.

The questions that separate a demo builder from an FDE.

01

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Questions and short answers

01 **Why does RAG return wrong answers?**

Usually retrieval: chunking, metadata or missing keywords.

02 **How do you evaluate it?**

Real questions, expert answers, retrieval and answer scored apart.

03 **Hybrid search?**

Keyword plus vector, then re-rank. Catches exact terms.

04 **How do you stop made-up answers?**

Require citations, allow “I don't know”, test it.

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Evals, the follow-ups

01 Where do eval cases come from?

Real tickets and the expert who would answer them.

02 LLM as judge?

Useful at scale, calibrated against human labels.

03 When do evals run?

On every prompt, model or retrieval change, in CI.

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Guardrails

WEAK ANSWER

- “We tell the model to be safe”
- One moderation API
- No tests
- Blocks everything risky

STRONG ANSWER

- Input, output and tool checks
- Permissions enforced in code
- Red-team set in CI
- Measured false-block rate

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How to answer

DO

- ✓ Start from the failure mode
- ✓ Name the metric you track
- ✓ Mention cost and latency
- ✓ Say what you would not build

AVOID

- ✗ List frameworks
- ✗ Claim 100% accuracy
- ✗ Skip evaluation
- ✗ Ignore the user's workflow

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Practise these

- [x] Debug a bad RAG answer aloud
- [x] Design a 50-case eval set
- [x] Explain hybrid search + re-ranking
- [x] Guardrails for a write action
- [x] Cost per answer, estimated

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KEY TAKEAWAY

Talk about failure modes and evals, not frameworks.

→ Retrieval causes most bad answers

→ Evals from real questions, run in CI

→ Guardrails live in code, not the prompt

YOUR TURN

Which LLM interview question do you find hardest to answer well?

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